

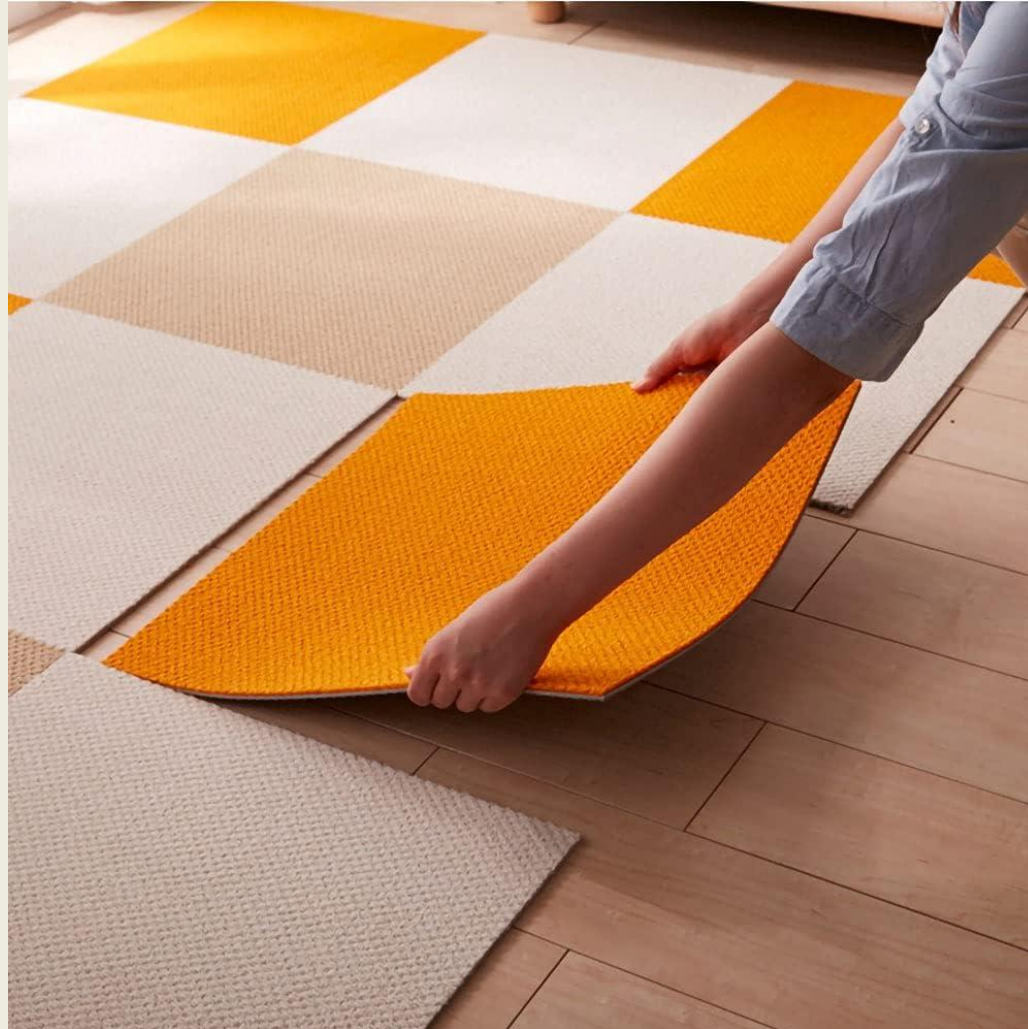


ENGINEERS IN ORGANIZATIONS

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Case



Engineers and Managers

- “There is a natural conflict between management and professionals because of their differences in educational background, socialization, values, vocational interests, work habits, and outlook” (Joseph Raelin)
- “Engineers often experience a conflict between loyalty to their employer and loyalty to their profession”
- Most managers are not engineers and do not have engineering expertise
- Many engineers aspire to management roles in the future

Engineers and Managers

- Robert Jackall's study:
- Managers prefer to think in terms of trade-offs between moral principles and utility
- Loyalty to ones peers and superiors is the primary virtue for managers
- Lines of responsibility are deliberately blurred to protect oneself, ones peers, and ones superiors
- Managers have a strong concern for the well-being of the organization. Well-being is measured primarily in financial terms, also includes a good public image and relatively conflict free operation

Being Morally Responsible in an Organization

- In order to be morally responsible in an organization, engineers must first have some understanding of the organization in which they are employed.
- This knowledge helps them to understand:
 - (1) how they and their managers tend to frame issues under the influence of the organization
 - (2) how one can act in the organization effectively, safely, and in a morally responsible way
- The Importance of Organizational Culture

Some Recommendations

- Engineers and other employees should be encouraged to report bad news
- Companies and their employees should adopt a position of critical loyalty
- When making criticisms and suggestions, focus on issues rather than personalities
- Written records should be kept of suggestions and especially of complaints
- Complaints should be kept as confidential as possible
- Provisions should be made for neutral participants from outside the organization
- Provision for protection from retaliation should be made
- The process for handling organizational disobedience should proceed as quickly as possible

Proper Engineering and Management Decisions

- How should we understand the boundary between decisions that should be made by engineers and those that should be made by managers?
- Functions of Engineers and Managers?

Proper Engineering and Management Decisions

BOX 4.4 Proper Engineering and Proper Management Decisions

- **Proper Engineering Decision (PED):** It is a decision that should be made by engineers or at least governed by professional engineering standards because it either involves technical matters that require engineering expertise or falls within the ethical standards embodied in engineering codes, especially those that require engineers to protect the health and safety of the public.
- **Proper Management Decision (PMD):** It is a decision that should be made by managers or at least governed by management considerations because it involves factors relating to the well-being of the organization, such as cost, scheduling, and marketing, and employee morale or welfare; and the decision does not force engineers (or other professionals) to make unacceptable compromises with their own technical or ethical standards.

Paradigmatic and Nonparadigmatic Examples

TABLE 4.1 A Paradigmatic PED

Feature	PMD	Test	PED
Technical expertise	Not needed	_____ X	Needed
Safety	Not important	_____ X	Important
Cost	Important	_____ X	Not important
Scheduling	Important	_____ X	Not important
Marketing	Important	_____ X	Not important

Responsible Dissent

- A Case to Consider: Richard M. Nixon v. Ernest Fitzgerald



What is Whistleblowing?

- One reveals information that the organization does not want to be shared with the public or some authority
- One does this outside of approved channels in the organization

Whistleblowing: A Harm-Preventing Justification

DeGeorge believes that whistle blowing is *morally permissible* provided that:

- the harm that will be done by the product to the public is serious and considerable
- the employees report their concern to their immediate superiors
- getting no satisfaction from their immediate superiors, they exhaust the channels available within the organization

DeGeorge believes that whistleblowing is *morally obligatory* provided that:

- the employee has documented evidence that would convince a responsible, impartial observer that his view of the situation is correct and the company policy is wrong
- the employee has strong evidence that making the information public will in fact prevent the threatened serious harm.

Whistleblowing: A Complicity-Avoiding View (Davis)

BOX 4.6 Complicity Theory and Whistleblowing

1. Within complicity theory, the whistleblower does not want to be complicit in wrongdoing in the organization.
2. Preventing harm to the company isn't essential for blowing the whistle.
3. Preventing harm to the public is desirable, but not a necessary part of the justification for whistleblowing.

Thanks

- Read the case 4.8 ROGER BOISJOLY AND THE CHALLENGER DISASTER